Frankfurter, Martinelli, Tesla Get Immigrant Merit Awards

Foreign-Born Citizens Honored at Annual Dinner; Harvard Law Professor Urges America to Keep Gates Open to Alien Refugees

Felix Frankfurter, professor of law at the Harvard Law School; Giovanni Martinelli, Metropolitan Opera tenor, and Dr. Nikola Tesla, physicist and inventor, received the third annual Awards of Merit, conferred by the National Institute of Immigrant Welfare on citizens of foreign birth, at the institute's annual dinner last night at the Biltmore.

Dr. Harry Woodburn Chase, chancellor of New York University and chairman of the committee which selected the recipients of the awards, made the presentations. Professor Frankfurter and Mr. Martinelli accepted their scrolls of honor in person. Dr. Telsa, who has not completely recovered from injuries suffered in an automobile accident six months ago, was represented by a friend, Dr. Paul R. Radosavljevich, professor of pedagogy at New York University.

Chase Reads Citations

Dr. Chase explained that the recipients were selected as representatives of different national groups "whose influence is national and international in scope, constructive in character and definite and purposeful in objectives." He used the following citations:

FELIX FRANKFURTER: Born in Vienna, he came to the United States at the age of twelve and was educated at the College of the City of New York and at Harvard University. After a period in the private practice of law, he served the Government of the United States in various capacities. In 1914 he became a member of the faculty of the Harvard Law School, where he has remained ever since. Stimulating in his teaching, prolific in his scholarly activities, his name is known nationally and internationally in his profession.

GIOVANNI MARTINELLI: Born in Italy, he came to the United States at the age of thirty-eight and ever since has identified his career with that of the Metropolitan Opera Company. He is known throughout the world as an artist of the best qualities of his people. He has enriched the land of his adoption in so many ways that the institute honors itself in honoring him.

DR. NIKOLA TESLA: Born in Jugoslavia, educated abroad, he began his practical career at Budapest and has continued it with distinction in this country since 1884. Inventor of the Tesla coil and imitator of forked lightning, author of the induction motor for the economic transformation of electrical energy into mechanical, inventor of the rotary magnetic field for capping power for mighty Niagara, his toys have been dynamos, transformers and condensers and he has found his relaxation while high voltage sparks crackled about him.

Professor Frankfurter, in accepting his award, said the stream of immigration to America had diminished, but the desire of the foreign-born to come to this country and the American need of them had not been reduced.

Urges Welcome for Refugees

"The times in which we live are bringing to American life doers of great deeds, thinkers of great thoughts and men and women undistinguished except as the sturdy foundation of every good society," he added. "We should welcome them as generations before us welcomed the pilgrims of '48. For they come not merely because persecution drives them, but because the American tradition beckons them."

Dr. Tesla, in a paper read for him by Dr. Radosavljevich, described his arrival in America, with only four cents in his pocket, to meet and work for the late Thomas A. Edison.

"The next day I was thrilled to the marrow by meeting Edison, who began my American education right then and there," he wrote. "I wanted to have my shoes shined, something I considered below my dignity. Edison said: 'Tesla, you will shine your shoes yourself and like it.' He impressed me tremendously. I shined my shoes and liked it."

Others who spoke before the 300 dinner guests were Leifur Magnusson, president of the institute; Dr. Henry Goddard Leach, editor of "The Forum"; Dr. Gregory Zilboorg, psychiatrist and author, and Dr. Leland Rex Robinson, banker and writer. The program also included a dance by the Svenska Folkdans Forening and Slavic songs by Maria Maximovitch, opera singer. The presentation of awards was broadcast by the National Broadcasting Company on a nation-wide hookup.

The award committee consisted of Dr. Chase, Dr. Leach, Dr. Stephen P. Duggan, director of the Institute of International Education; Dr. John H. Finley, editor of "The New York Times," and Dr. James T. Shotwell, of Columbia University. The recipients last year were Dr. Ales Hrdlicka, Henry Morgenthau sr. and Dr. Leo H. Backeland.